withdrew its remaining ships toward Okinawa, leaving the islands undefended except for fighters based at New Ishigaki Airport, which was converted to military use.

The Japanese had another card to play, however, and in the early morning hours of September 22, the *Shoryu* (SS-510), a *Soryu*-class diesel-electric attack submarine that had been lurking southwest of the Senkakus, intercepted the *Liaoning* and loosed four Type 89 guided torpedoes, two of which struck the Chinese aircraft carrier below the waterline. The *Liaoning* was halted and began to list, at which point the *Shoryu* surfaced and launched six Harpoon missiles, four of which found their target, leaving the *Liaoning* out of commission and severely listing to port. Four Chinese attack submarines that had been in Taiwanese waters then hunted down the *Shoryu*, sinking her with all sixty-five hands on board just before midnight on September 23, southeast of Okinawa, where she was making a run for sanctuary.

When intelligence of the disabling of the *Liaoning* reached East Sea Fleet headquarters at Ningbo, the assumption was made that an American submarine had attacked the carrier. In response, orders went out to retaliate by targeting the *Gerald Ford*, which had turned north from the Batanes after receiving word of the battle off the Senkakus. Again, the Chinese launched DF-21D antiship ballistic missiles; unlike on September 16, however, two missiles found their target after ineffective SM-6 countermeasures. The *Gerald Ford* sustained catastrophic damage and severe loss of life, and the ship foundered at nightfall. Japanese and American ships sent out from Okinawa reached the scene late on September 23 and commenced rescue operations, and the USS *John C. Stennis* hove into view the following day.

V. The Choice for Peace: September 23–30, 2025

The successful attacks on the aircraft carriers of both nations were the turning point of the Littoral War. Senior policy makers in both countries realized they were now at the precipice of full-out conflict, where